

me" in the Slack message field and hit Enter to open the request form after you have previously opened the workflow at least once.

Fill out the form to the best of your ability, including as much detail and context that will be helpful for an SME to engage.

The form includes fields for the Account Name, SFDC Opportunity URL, type of engagement being requested, the next customer meeting date and time zone, and how long you expect the engagement to last.

The form is backed by an internal spreadsheet for capturing the relevant details and other metadata for the request.

Engagement process:

A SME will reach out through Slack to the person making the request typically within 24 hours.

If a SME does not engage within 24 hours, the SME Area Lead will work with the SME team members to get someone engaged.

The SME will add their name in the associated SME request spreadsheet to ensure assignment is confirmed.

The SME will use a green checkmark emoji on the SME Request message in the Slack channel to indicate that an SME has engaged.

Completion and Follow-up:

After the engagement, the person making the request will provide feedback on the SME's engagement and contribution to help improve the process in the SME Request spreadsheet, under Feedback Notes Column.

Please also enter if a followup with the Product Manager is needed as Feedback.

Reporting and attribution:

The SME will use the Activity Type "SA Assistance - Subject Matter" when logging activities in Rattle, or SFDC.

Rules of Engagement

When you Request A SME:

1. Lead Time: SMEs should be requested at least 48 hours before needed. if it is an emergency contact your manager, who can follow the escalation process to engage a SME or PM.
2. Give Full Context in Request: Don't just say I want a SME to join a call or the customer has questions. You need to be explicit on what exactly are those questions the customer has. If you don't know ask the customer before engaging a SME.
3. Prep Call Required: If the request is to join a customer meeting, when the SME has accepted, have a prep call ahead of that meeting.
4. Agenda Required: Ensure you do have an Agenda created and this was communicated with the customer. Ensure you have a next steps and clear outcomes for the meeting.
5. Complete Discovery Before: Please ensure that all necessary discovery has occurred before you requested a SME and that you have documented as such.
6. Resist from Directly contacting PM Without a SME Request in certain scenarios. See below.
7. Use SME Channels: All request should be made in the SME channels and not in Customer slack channels etc.

Before Engaging or Requesting A PM Consider Requesting a SME First {sme-pm-alternative}

It is the goal for the SMEs to become experts in AI, Dedicated, App Security, Plan, CICD and Metrics, so that they can assist account teams and customers in adopting and using them. We need to reduce the burden on Product Managers to teach the field and customers on how to use the product.

Resist from Directly contacting PM Without First completing a SME Request: If an AE, a SA, or CSM requests a PM, Field CTO directly, ask the requester, to first consider requesting a SME. You, the SA/ CSM can then request a SME in the appropriate SME channel. PMs have been directed to redirect all questions to SMEs by the use of the SME Slack handles, if they determine that the SMEs were not initially engaged, and the request is not associated with any escalations, or request for product direction.

For these scenarios, please engage the SME community before engaging a PM.

In lieu of directly engaging Product management, SMEs should be requested or engaged in the appropriate sme- slack channel, for one of the following scenarios:

1. Answering Technical Questions

1. Ask the question in the sme- channel using the Stack Overflow command /stack ask, and have a SME answer it.

2. If questions are asked in a customer channel or in the f channels, Product Managers are free to redirect these questions to the SMEs using the SME Slack handles.

2. Request for Content.

3. Request for a Demo.

4. Request for Best Practices.

5. Request to Speak at a Conference.

6. Request to join a Customer Call, in order to conduct a demo, discuss best practices or just to answer technical questions.

7. During a POV, and help is needed. Engage a SME in the sme- channel, to help first triage the situation. You, along with the SME, before engaging a PM should do the following:

1. Gather the required detail information (customer configuration, steps to reproduce etc.)

2. Search existing documentation (internal or external) or past issues for a solution

3. Ask other SMEs or Support using the Super Support Form for help

4. SMEs can also reach out to PMs for one off questions or gain more clarification.

8. Request for reference architecture cost estimates or Creating a Dedicated pricing calculator for an opportunity. See example

When to Engage a Product Manager

Please see SME Engagement with Product Management for a full discussion on how SAs, CSMs, and SMEs, should now engage with PMs alongside the SME Program.

During Customer calls with a SME

1. Prep: Have a prep call ahead of that meeting with all parties involved.

2. Clear Agenda, Next Steps, Outcomes: Ensure you do have an Agenda and this was communicated with the customer. Ensure you have a next steps and clear outcomes for the meeting.

3. SA/ CSM Quarterback Technical Calls: The SA/ CSMs should be the one to run the call. Don't

have a SME join and just turn it over to the SME.

4. Note Taking: SAs should share the Notes doc to the SMEs for everyone to collaborate. However the SAs/ CSMs are responsible for capturing all notes.

5. Retro: Have a Retro After the Call, to determine follow ups. See the below for SME follow ups and actions to be taken.

After the SME Engagement: How to Record Feedback/ Followups; Actions per Request Type

General Guidance

1. If there are a a lot of follow ups or feedback needed for the customer, Create a \<Customer> SME Support Feedback Issue in the SME Area Project under the SME Collaboration Group, with appropriate action items.
2. Add all the Action Items needed. Action Items can be in the form of:
 1. Technical Questions to be Answered (with list of Questions)
 2. Request for a Demo
 3. Request for Best Practices
 4. Request for Content to be Created
 5. Request for a PM/ Customer Enhancement
3. Link this issue to any Customer Issues in the Customer Project.

These are the Actions SMEs should take for each type of follow ups or request type below

Technical Questions to be Answered (with list of Questions) {sme-questions}

Any SA or CSM can ask a technical question in the appropriate sme- channel using the Stack Overflow command /stack ask, and have a SME answer it.

If a list of technical questions were sent before a customer call, or after as a follow up, the SME can take these addiitonal actions:

1. If you believe that this request could have been prevented with better Discovery or you think this is an opportunity to add to the Discovery Questions, please go to the Contents & Collaterals Issue (see Dedicated example) for the appropriate SME Area in the SME Collaboration Project and add your Discovery questions for the good of the whole orh.
2. If questions came up with the customer, where the answers should be shared with SAs and CSMs, as an action item add to StackOverflow (TBD on process), and/or add the question and answer to each SME Area FAQ (See Contents & Collaterals Issue in the SME Collaboration Project)
3. If this a topic for all SAs or CSMs or even other SMEs to be enabled on, Please go to your SME Area Collaboration Project and add to the List of Topics for SMEs Enablement (See Dedicated example), SMEs can then discuss at next SME meeting, or bring PMs in on next PM/ SME Cadence, and also present on the next Technical Exchange

Request for Demo {sme-demo}

1. If a Demo was requested, as the SME please record your demo before hand, or record the customer call on Gong if possible, and add that Demo on the SME Hub on Highspot or Demo Excellence Catalog.

Request for Content to Be Shared {sme-content}

If an SA or CSM requests for content to be shared, or to be created, the process is as follows:

1. Go to the SME Hub in HighSpot
2. Go to the appropriate SME Area
3. Click on the button "Request New Content" or New Content Request"
4. An Issue template would come up for you to fill out. Be very clear and explicit, with lots of content in your request. See this "Request for Dedicated Onboarding Content" as an example.
5. Tag it with SME Workflow::Create. See all other tags here
6. Share the Issue on the sme- channel.

Note: The SMEs are not necessary responsible for creating or producing every content request it receives. This is a request for SMEs to share existing assets when requested, and make it available in HighSpot. SMEs will prioritize incoming requests as needed and will work to identify the right resource to create any new content as necessary.

This is the list of Content, SMEs are responsible for creating or gathering:

- List of discovery questions\
- Frequently asked questions\
- List of any Recorded enablement sessions\
- Work with PMs for Golden demos\
- Hands-on workshops\
- Technical evaluation guidelines\
- POV templates\
- Competitive intelligence

Request for Best Practices {sme-best-practice}

If this is a request for Best Practices/ Architectural principles, in the SME Projects in the SME Collaboration Group do the following:

1. Add to the list for request for Best practices, Knowledge Base, Architectural Blueprints (See Dedicated Issue as an example) in the appropriate SME Collab Project.
2. If you decide to give an answer to best practices make sure and put your writeup in StackOverflow (Process TBD) or at least as an Issue in your SME Area
3. If you need discussion around this, meet with SMEs during Pod Meetings to discuss and codify your best practices in Stack Overflow (Process TBD) or at least as a new issue in your SME Area

Note: SMEs will prioritize incoming requests as needed and will work to identify the right resource to create any new content as necessary.

Request for a PM/ Customer Enhancement {sme-pm}

If you need to follow up with a PM, or the customer requested an enhancement or has a feedback, following the SME Customer Feedback Process (TBD) and accomplish the following:

1. Create a Customer feedback issue in the Customer GitLab Project. Be very clear on the ask and feedback

2. Tag the PM on that Issue or follow the PMs escalation Process
3. As the SME, engage the PMs on your SME Internal Slack Channel
4. If this is a challenge affecting multiple customers, as a SME create an Epic as described in the Customer Feedback process (TBD). and link this and all other Customer Issues that were created based on a common theme etc. Ask your fellow SMEs to message in their regions to collect customer issues that are experiencing the same.
5. During SME calls review the SME Issue boards
6. During the SME/ PM Calls review the SME Issue Boards and update as needed.

SECTION: solutions-architects/sa-practices/value-stream-discovery/index.md

When working with GitLab, many prospects and customers have software delivery performance improvements as critical business outcomes. Unfortunately, due to the inherent and increasing complexity in the software delivery process, an organization's software delivery value streams often consist of dozens, if not hundreds, of manual configuration touch points and handoffs. Typically, there is a lack of visibility and understanding into the current process, making it challenging to identify and measure software delivery improvements. Without understanding the current software development value streams, organizations risk putting time, effort, and money into areas that will not improve their software delivery capability in any meaningful way.

GitLab account teams should offer to assist prospects and customers in helping to provide an overview and understanding of their value stream(s).

The content on this page outlines the various approaches, tools, and artifacts we have available to help achieve a better understanding of our prospects and customers value streams. With this better understanding of the current state; identifying bottlenecks and establishing a baseline measurement of software delivery performance, GitLab can ensure our prospects and customers can achieve their critical business outcomes through implementation of impactful changes and improvements, delivered quickly and continuously.

Approaches

At GitLab, the Value Stream Discovery process can be tailored to accommodate the diverse needs of our clients, ranging from basic discussions to elaborate explorations filled with metrics and data.

The journey might commence with a straightforward conversation, offering initial insights into software delivery challenges and business goals impacted. Another, more detailed starting point, could involve multiple discussions with various teams, providing a holistic yet concise view of the current software delivery processes, yet without delving deeply into metrics. An alternative more 'hands-on' experience could be in the form of a full-day session, focusing on 'a day in the life' of a developer, offering practical insights into daily workflows. Finally, for those who require a strategic, in-depth and outcome driven approach, we offer comprehensive, executive-sponsored workshops. These structured, multi-day, multi-team events present an end-to-end overview of the entire value stream, complete with detailed metrics and tailored recommendations.

This spectrum of approaches, from simple dialogues to intensive workshops, ensures that we can

adapt to the varying depths of engagement required, with a constant aim to deliver relevant and impactful insights for enhancing our clients' software delivery efficiency and effectiveness.

Value Stream Discovery Sessions

Value Stream Discovery (VSD) aims to gain a clear understanding of how an organization or a set of teams delivers value to its customers. VSD can be conducted using a variety of techniques, depending on objectives, time commitment, and the available level of customer/team engagement.

Common Value Stream Discovery Techniques

Discovery Session (with Value Stream Concepts): Integrate value stream mapping concepts into standard discovery sessions. This aligns well with GitLab's Command of the Message approach, focusing on understanding the customer's current state, future desired state, and the metrics they'll use to measure success. It's vital to grasp how the customer's value stream ties into achieving their larger business goals.

"Day in the Life": Leverage the established "Day in the Life" SA practice to extract valuable value stream information. While initial observations might be limited to a single team, the resulting metrics and insights provide a valid foundation. Ideally, expand this exercise to involve multiple teams within the value stream for greater cross-functional visibility.

Value Stream Discovery Session (Informal): A focused session involving representatives from across the value stream. Less structured than a full workshop, it still prioritizes understanding the customer's value stream with the potential to identify immediate improvement areas if time allows.

Value Stream Workshop: A comprehensive approach detailed below in this handbook page.

Customer-Focused Techniques

Since Value Stream Discovery aims to uncover challenges in delivering value to the end-user, techniques focusing on them can be valuable:

Customer Journey Mapping: Visualize the customer's experience as they interact with the value stream. Map touchpoints, identify pain points, and uncover opportunities to improve their journey, enhancing overall delivered value (Lucidchart Overview).

Voice of the Customer (VOC): Employ surveys, interviews, or user testing to collect direct feedback from end-users on their experience with the value stream. This qualitative data provides insights into their needs, frustrations, and areas for improvement (Gainsight Overview).

Choosing a Technique

Factors to consider when selecting the most suitable approach include:

Time constraints: Simpler techniques are easier to fit into busy schedules.

Level of Engagement: Does the customer/team have the bandwidth for in-depth workshops, or would a less intensive approach be more suitable?

Urgency: Are there immediate pain points the value stream could address? Simpler techniques could offer faster insights.

Desired Outcome: Is the goal a high-level understanding, or a detailed action plan necessitating a full workshop?

Important Note: Regardless of the technique selected, the core aim of Value Stream Discovery is to collaboratively understand the customer's process of delivering value, identify inefficiencies, and pinpoint opportunities for optimization.

Value Stream Workshop

Process

1. Qualify the Opportunity for a Value Stream Workshop
1. Educate potential participants and obtain commitment to the workshop
1. Prepare for the Value Stream Workshop
1. Initial customer positioning
1. Plan the Value Stream Workshop
1. Facilitate the Value Stream Workshop
1. Executive Briefing - Summarize the findings
1. Contribute back to this framework

Qualify

Running a Value Stream Workshop requires a non-trivial investment of time by both the GitLab field teams and our prospects and customers. To ensure the appropriate return on this investment of time, the opportunities should meet the following criteria, and if not, please give any justification for why an exception should be made:

We have a strong relationship with an executive sponsor

The account has a total addressable market of at least 1000 GitLab users (100 users for Commercial Accounts)

The prospect or customer is focused on improving their software delivery performance or related practices (e.g., securing their software supply chain, cloud migrations, application modernization, developer experience and efficiency)

We have a relationship with the economic buyer

We have identified and established a relationship with the internal champion

We suggest positioning a Value Stream Workshop prior to POVs (Proof of Value) to understand bottlenecks, key metrics important to stakeholder. This also gives us an opportunity to agree to the success criteria before starting the POV as value drivers for deal closure.

Key indicators that the opportunity is well-suited include:

There is a specific initiative to accomplish one or more of the following by a specific date

Improve developer experience and efficiency

Transform or objectively improve their ability to deliver software

Modernize their DevOps capabilities

Secure their software supply chain

Modernize a specific application or applications

Deliver a new critical application to the market

Migration to the cloud

The customer is currently using some features of GitLab and is interested in how leveraging more of the platform will drive software delivery outcomes

For customer success, a value stream workshop should help uncover opportunities to expand into new use cases or improve current adoption by identifying bottlenecks in the current software

delivery value stream

An existing customer shows interest in adopting our value stream analytics feature to drive software delivery performance

The scope of a value stream workshop should always be clearly defined. A clearly defined scope ensures that the correct people are being included in the team and reduces the risk of time lost agreeing what should be focussed on. For this reason, the scope of a GitLab facilitated workshop must always be within the DevSecOps space.

Education and Commitment

A successful value stream workshop requires a commitment to the workshop by the software delivery stakeholders and the personnel experienced with the various processes that constitute their value stream. Without understanding the process and its value to their organization, participants will lack the commitment to ensure a successful value stream workshop. Educate the prospect or customer on the benefits, process details, and the required commitment. Leverage the Value Stream Workshop Positioning Deck - (Recording) by customizing it for the prospect or customer to assist with this step.

While a Value Stream Workshop is an advanced discovery session, it's expected that initial opportunity discovery and technical discovery have both been conducted prior.

Key Benefits

Discovery and documentation of the software delivery value stream or "path to production" currently in place

Establish an agreed upon baseline from which to measure the progress of software delivery performance

Identify manual configuration touchpoints and handoffs and other value stream bottlenecks

Create a process improvement roadmap

Understand the return on investment of a value delivery platform

Promote collaboration amongst traditionally siloed functions within the DevSecOps lifecycle

After the prospect or customer understands the process and its benefits, confirm commitment from the stakeholders and workshop participants by scheduling the facilitated workshop and/or interviews. Estimate the duration of the discovery session and set the expectation that the documented value stream, recommendations, and readout will be delivered.

What is The Required Time Commitment?

Focusing on the goals and benefits listed above, the time required to complete a minimally viable value stream workshop will vary from organization to organization. The workshop should NOT require exhaustive discussion and research. Depending on the availability and commitment of the various value stream participants and stakeholders, the practice could take as little as 4 hours to complete or up to 15 hours spread out through multiple sessions over multiple days.

Prepare

Value Stream Workshop Tracking Issue

The very first step when considering a value stream workshop is to notify the Value Stream Discovery team of the intent, and provide as much information as possible regarding the prospect/customer. To do so:

Please create a new issue in value stream discovery project
Use the template labeled requestvaluestreamassessment

This gives the team at GitLab the ability to both track the progress of the Value Stream Discovery and allocate team members to the effort, a key requirement for the next preparation steps.

Internal Preparation Meeting

It is extremely important to have an internal preparation meeting (can be async) prior to positioning a Value Stream Workshop to the customer. The goal of the meeting is to be able to discuss:

The opportunity (should include SFDC link for SA engagement)
The key players & their roles
What metrics are these key players measured by
Any OKRs for these key players that the account team is aware of
What will be the successful outcome from a Value Stream Workshop
Pick key slides to deliver to customer
Pick key discovery questions to be asked during positioning & customer planning session
Important chorus recordings to review
Identify and communicate to a GitLab Executive Sponsor

Position

The initial customer positioning allows us to position value stream assesment to our key stakeholders & get their buy in. The customer positioning should include:

What is a Value Stream Workshop?
What does a Value Stream Workshop entail?
Who are the key participants involved in the Value Stream Workshop?
What are some of the expected outcomes of a Value Stream Workshop for them?

It is important to identify a project or few projects as next step for the planning meeting with customer.

Here are some resources that can be used as starting point for the positioning session:

Customer positioning deck - (Recording)
Internal positioning deck

Planning meeting with customer

Planning a Value Stream Workshop can generally be done within an hour, given the right expectation, focus and people involved.

It is recommended that when planning a Value Stream Workshop, a Value Stream Transformation Charter should be used.

Define Value Stream

What is the value stream that is to be mapped?

Where does the mapping process start and end?

What context or conditions are being considered?

What triggering event initiates the work flowing through the value stream?

What is the demand rate? (The volume of incoming work per day, week, month, etc. relating to this value stream)

(Optionally) Which team, project, feature, etc. is being mapped?

Define boundaries and limitations

When looking at desired future state, it is very likely there will be certain limitations that the team needs to operate within (financial, systems, customer, organisational, physical, etc)

This is critical to avoid creating an unrealistic desired future state, or one that's simply not achievable in the defined time frame

Define the time frame (How quickly do they need to realise the future state?)

Without the answers to these questions we risk spending significant time and energy trying to understand each possible variation and often will end up with metrics that are hard to define (the "it depends" trap). As such, it's critically important that these definitions are confirmed and agreed upon prior to the workshop (generally as part of the planning meeting).

Value Stream Workshop

People

Process

Tools

Workflows

Questions

People

| Role | Responsibilities | GitLab Roles |

| ----- | ----- |----- |

| Scribe(s) |A team member who's primary purpose is to document the session, capture key metrics as they emerge which will later be used to create a executive briefing template. | AE, Shadow SA, CSM |

| Facilitator |A team member fully versed in the Value Stream Mapping process who is responsible for leading the session; ensuring that discussion is staying on-topic, at the right level and at the required pace. | SA |

| Account Leader |Ensure that the long term strategic vision for the prospect is considered when discussing desired future state and they can also provide additional context to the current state. Schedule meetings with the Value Stream Workshop participants. Send summary followup emails after each session (template)Update VSW Tracking fields in Salesforce.| AE |

Process

The process which we will go through, at a high level, is as follows (per functional persona/team, in a single workshop or across a few meetings):

1. Why we are here? (Exec sponsor led)
1. Re-iterate expectations set in the planning meeting
 1. Start and end points for the value stream
1. Current state
 1. Initial process "walk-through" / information discovery
 1. Capture people, processes and technology per persona/team (information discovery guide)
 1. 2nd process "walk-through" (if needed)
1. Design future state (when doing a single workshop with all personas or in the planning meeting with your sponsor)
 1. Review the expectations again, to align the team on the target they are aiming to create
 1. Determine "right work" (which processes and steps are required for the value stream to be optimal)
 1. Remove processes and process steps when they are truly unnecessary
 1. Add processes and process steps when they can increase overall process time and lead time
 1. Making work flow
 1. Aim to reduce the lead time (LT), process time (PT) and achieve a higher percent complete and accurate (%C&A) for every process block where possible
 1. Use Lean countermeasures and improvement tools
 1. Managing the work
 1. How will we measure if the value stream is performing as we intended? (KPIs)
 1. Who will monitor and manage the value stream performance?

Tools

Remote:

Google Sheets - Value Stream Mapping Template

Zoom, MS Teams, or Google Meet

LucidChart for Value Stream Map visualization

LucidChart is an IT-managed application. If you are unsure if you have LucidChart access, go to the Okta interface in your browser, then select "Search Your Apps" and see if LucidChart SSO is available. If yes, LucidChart has been assigned to you and you can launch it from Okta and collaborate on any LucidChart Documents your team has shared with you. If no, then LucidChart SSO has not been assigned to you yet.

If you do not have LucidChart SSO assigned to you in Okta, please navigate to the "access-requests" Project and submit an Issue requesting "Lucid Chart". Assign the Issue to your Manager and add the IT::to do label. An example Access Request Issue may be found here.

If your Access Request is urgent, paste the link to your Access Request Issue into the ithelp Slack channel and @ mention it-help with a note on why it is urgent.

Onsite:

Stickies

Pens

Large whiteboard

Example Workflows

1. Idea to Production
1. Response to Production Incident
1. Toolchain Upgrading and Maintenance

Idea to Production

Response to Production Incident

Toolchain Upgrading and Maintenance

Executive Briefing - Summarize the Findings

The final meeting as part of the Value Stream Workshop process is the findings and next steps presentation (though it's called an executive presentation, it's expected to be a two-way discussion). The high level topics of this meeting are:

1. Summary of planning outcomes; what process was to be mapped and what target goals were created
1. Summary of the current state mapping (with VSM diagram)
1. Summary of the proposed future state mapping (with VSM diagram)
1. Highlight the key differences, expected process and business benefits
1. Walkthrough of recommendations
1. Walkthrough and gain agreement for the transformation plan. The transformation plan should be built in conjunction with professional services to yield best results. Please read how to position professional services in an opportunity [here](#)
1. Define next steps and suggest a review date

Example template of the executive briefing can be found [here](#). Please modify accordingly to suit your customer's need.

It is recommended to review the executive briefing with your champion, key stakeholder before the final meeting to collect additional feedback. The goal is to then deliver it jointly to the broader team to gain agreement.

FAQs from customers/prospects

1. What's in it for me - the customer?

Free, hands-on consultative analysis of their software delivery lifecycle, including their current state, future state, and areas of improvements.

Competitive analysis of where they are compared to their peers in the industry. This report contains the most recent benchmark values for the four DORA metrics (widely regarded as good measures of DevOps performance) State of DevOps Report 2021.

Recommendations on how to overcome visible or invisible challenges with a strategic plan to help them reach their future state.

1. What are typical outcomes for a customer?

For one medical device company in Silicon Valley, doing a Value Stream Workshop provided them with a tangible adoption plan to decrease their release cycle from 6 months to 1 months. It was specific, actionable, and realistic.

For a financial service bank, doing a Value Stream Workshop provided them with a comparison of their process with their peers, and the clear path forward to improve their processes, and ultimately allowed them to achieve a desired ROI of releasing software faster while increasing quality.

Financial Services customers have realized the below outcomes when coupling a Value Stream Workshop with GitLab investment:

- Faster time to market

- Increase deployment frequency

- Reduced lead time to change

- Improved change failure rate

- Necessary capabilities obtained to drive transformation change (e.g., digital, DevOps, software delivery, modern applications)

1. Which teams are typically involved?

We start with application development team, quality engineering team, DevOps then application security.

1. What's the best place to start?

Pick the most business critical application or a representative application that has faster time to market requirement.

1. That's a lot of time investment from our teams Or Our teams are busy with other projects.

It takes 1 or 1.5 hr per team to do focused discovery for a Value Stream Workshop. We interviewed 4 different teams for our silicon valley customer in 4.5 hrs. We can start with the least busy team if you don't want it to be pursued in a group setting.

1. Can you interview 1 team at a time?

Yes. We would like to start with application development team if so. This helps us understand an overview of their development process(idea-production) process.

Salesforce Tracking

Three minute video overview covering the fields and process described below.

The Account Leader (AE) is responsible for maintaining the Salesforce opportunity level VSW Tracking Fields outline below:

VSW Start Date - Date of the VSW kickoff call with the prospect/customer.(This is the first meeting with the prospect/customer, after they've committed to do a VSW, to discuss planning of the VSW workshop.)

VSW End Date - The date the VSW readout is presented to the prospect/customer or the date of the last meeting with the prospect if the VSW status is set to "Stalled."

VSW Status - The status of the VSW where

Planning - Internal qualification and planning is occurring. Please remove the status if it becomes unqualified during this step. VSW start date should not be set when this status is set.

Pitched - We've positioned a VSW with the prospect/customer. VSW start date should not be set when this status is set.

Accepted - When the customer has agreed to do a VSW and has scheduled a kickoff call. VSW start date should not be set when this status is set.

In-process - We've had a kickoff call, are actively facilitating the VSW, or are compiling the result for the readout.

Completed - We have presented the VSW executive readout to the prospect/customer. VSW End Date should be set.

Stalled - We were in-process but the prospect/customer is non-responsive and we can't schedule additional interviews. VSW End Date should be set.

VSW Readout - The sentiment from the VSW Readout meeting.

Positive - The prospect/customer was highly receptive to our recommendations and we have progressive next steps.

Neutral - The prospect/customer was receptive but we do not have clear next steps.

Negative - The prospect/customer was not receptive to our recommendation.

VSW URL - The URL to the google drive folder containing the readout presentation and any other VSW artifacts.

VSW Start Date Net ARR - (Auto populated field) The opportunity Net ARR when the VSW start date is populated.

Solutions Architects should leverage the following SA Activity Types when logging activity

VSW Pitch

VSW Execution

Training and Enablement

The single source of truth for training and VSW artifacts can be found on the associated HighSpot page.

Value Stream Workshop Overview

This course is designed to provide an overview of how GitLab account teams should assist prospects and customers by providing a lightweight assessment of their value stream. The course outlines the approaches, tools, and artifacts used to conduct a value stream assessment for our prospects and customers.

GitLab Value Stream Workshop Accreditation on LevelUp

Past Enablement

2023-03-23 Webcast - Winning With Value Stream Assessments - Jonathan Fullam

2022-02-03 Webcast - Value Stream Assessment - Simon Mansfield, Reshmi Krishna

How to Contribute

In the spirit of collaboration and iteration, please help to continuously improve this framework. Ways to contribute include:

Create a merge request to improve this page

Add feedback or tasks to the Value Stream Workshop Issue

Share your experiences in the customer-success and solutions-architects slack channels

Provide feedback and/or updates to the positioning deck or provide links to your own variations

Provide links to your facilitation recordings, summary documentation, and/or other artifacts to this page

Collaborate in the value-stream-discovery slack channel

SECTION: solutions-architects/sa-practices/whiteboard-based-facilitation/_index.md

Why Use a Whiteboard?

Whiteboards are a powerful facilitation tool that drives active participation from the audience and captures ideas/feedback visually in real-time. They allow for a more natural flow of conversation, unlike slideshows which present static, prepared content. The whiteboard becomes a shared artifact that provides immediate value to participants, creates a shared understanding between all parties, and builds trust between participants. This page provides whiteboard templates that can be immediately applied to regular SA practices.

Primary Objectives

1. Whiteboarding should facilitate better the discovery of:
 1. Customer's initiatives and challenges
 1. Customer's toolchain
 1. Customer's current state and workflows
 1. Customer's pain points and bottlenecks
 1. Key teams/personas involved

Available Templates

The library of whiteboard templates are in the SA Whiteboard and Pitch Catalog FigJam Team. For access, open an Access Request and ensure you are added to the Solutions Architecture team.

1. End to End GitLab Value
1. End to End Gitlab People and Process
1. Premium to Ultimate Discusion
1. Current State Discovery
1. Example Value Stream
1. Value Stream Workshop
1. Day-in-the-Life of a Developer
1. Post-POV Retrospective

SECTION: solutions-architects/tools-and-resources/_index.md

Tools and Resources

Tools and resources provide infomation to help Solutions Architects to conduct POV or workshops, respond to RFX, manage customer facing activities, support on-going product learning.

Education and Enablement

As a Solutions Architect, it is important to be continuously learning more about our product and related industry topics. The education and enablement handbook page provides a dashboard of aggregated resources that we encourage you to use to get up to speed.

Proof of Value (POV) Guidelines

Proof of Value (POV), formerly known as Proof of Concept, is conducted during the Technical Evaluation stage with Solutions Architects by prospects or existing customers to assess the required capabilities based on a set of criteria and value drivers. A POV is a collaboration between GitLab and the prospective or existing customer for evaluating GitLab. Information on the POV guidelines, POV types and process can be found on the [Proof of Value \(POV\) Guidelines](#) page.

Asking help from Support Engineering

In case Support required during the pre-sales cycle (for example in case of a POV exercise or in case of potential new deal with an existing customer) Solutions Architects should use the Support Super Form to open an internal request with Support. In any other cases with existing customers, SAs are advised to ask the customers to open a support ticket themselves.

SaaS Trials for Existing Customers

Paid customers must set up a new namespace on SaaS when trialing Ultimate. There are two primary reasons for this:

1. Some paid features are not available in a trial, so a customer might lose functionality they had been using if a trial license is applied
2. GitLab does not have an appropriate mechanism for applying and reverting a trial license on SaaS without the namespace potentially being reverted to free when the trial expires (see [issue](#))

Both situations put customer production GitLab usage at risk if a trial is applied to the SaaS namespace.

Instead, a customer should create a new namespace and trial there. We have put together some trial guidelines in order to make the process as seamless as possible for customers.

Hands-on Workshops

GitLab Solutions Architects conduct hands-on workshops as interactive events for GitLab prospects and customers to learn the GitLab product and DevSecOps capabilities. Workshops may be executed as marketing events or run independently for specific customers. Detail information is provided on the [Hands-on Workshops](#) page.

RFI/RFP Responses

RFx's such as RFI and RFP are common steps in the public sector yet it may be required by enterprise customers to assess, evaluate and procure the software. Solutions architects often

participate in the RFP process responding to the technical asks and solutions requirements. Information on responding to the RFx can be found on the RFI/RFP page.

Stack Overflow for Teams

Stack Overflow for Teams is a knowledge sharing and collaboration tool that helps many organizations at Gitlab, including the SA org, stay productive, onboard faster, and minimize distractions by unlocking information through collaborative knowledge management.

Please refer to the Stack Overflow resource page to understand how Stack Overflow is utilized by the SA, CS, and SMB orgs.

Product Releases

Solutions Architects have to keep up the pace of the GitLab monthly product releases to position feature sets and capabilities for the prospect and customer needs while demonstrating the market leading position.

Following links provide product release information to assist in technical discussions and technical evaluation.

- Upcoming Releases
- Previous Releases
- Releases Blog
- Compare two releases with the What is New Since? Release Feature Overview Tool

Customer Facing Meeting Tools

Solutions Architects frequently interact with customers for demos, presentations or Q&A. These calls should enable the customer to clearly experience the value of GitLab without distraction or interruption. The below list of tools was compiled by the GitLab SA team as commonly used solutions. Note, this list does not represent a requirement to use any of these products or an endorsement for these products.

- Muzzle to mute all notifications prior to beginning a call
- Tab Resize Chrome plugin to break tabs into split-screen viewing
- Screenbrush to draw on the screen
- Toby or Tabs Outliner to launch many preset tabs at once
- Station to group pages by application in a smart dock
- MouseBeam enables the mouse cursor to use multiple screens like a circle
- Rectangle to quickly move and resize windows in macOS using keyboard shortcuts or snap areas
- Dark Reader enables browser dark mode to better fit room lighting
- Postman for API interaction
- Visual Studio Code lightweight IDE text editor

Related macOS tips

- Switch between full screen applications using the trackpad, Command keys or other options
- Use the Zoom Accessibility Features to zoom in on targeted screen locations
- Work in multiple spaces on a single monitor to keep multiple app windows or browser tabs open

in fullscreen mode

- Enables switching between windows or tabs with trackpad gestures, keeping display screen clean and uncluttered

Useful Customer Facing Presentations

No two presentations are the same and we often find ourselves mixing and matching content tailored to our Customer's journey. All field and customer facing collateral is hosted on

- HighSpot (for field teams)
- Solution Pages (for web users)

O'Reilly Learning Platform

In order to facilitate an environment of learning and development, the Solutions Architect team has access to the O'Reilly Learning Platform. This education platform contains thousands of books, videos and live learning courses to assist SA's with gaining the knowledge they need to stay competitive.

More information can be found on the Customer Success Education & Enablement page.

LinkedIn Learning Platform

LinkedIn Learning is another platform with various resources to help SA's during their onboarding journeys.

Getting started as an associate SA

Here are courses that will facilitate the onboarding process of associate SAs and help them in getting up to speed with the technical concepts required for the role:

Free for GitLab members

- The learning path Become a DevOps Engineer, particularly the following sections:
 - DevOps Foundations
 - Learning Docker
 - DevOps Foundations - CI/CD
- Docker for the Absolute Beginner - Hands-On

Paid

Paid courses can be expensed as part of the Growth and Development benefits

- IBM course on Coursera: Information Technology (IT) and Cloud Fundamentals Specialization
Especially the module Introduction to Cloud Computing

Data Seeding (Demo Data)

The GitLab Data Seeder is a tool that Solutions Architects can use to showcase to customers "what good data looks like" in GitLab.

The data that is generated is customizable, time-relative, and can be used on-demand to generate data to demonstrate.

The Demo Data can be showcased on any self-managed instance including Docker, GDK, and customer environments.

Diagramming Tools

Being able to diagram as-is and to-be workflows and architectures is a key tactic for Solutions Architects to communicate key benefits of a GitLab DevSecOps transformation. GitLab has made FigJam available for SAs to use and we have Solutions Architecture Workspace available for storing our diagrams.

SECTION: solutions-architects/tools-and-resources/rfp.md

RFI/RFP Process

A Request for Information (RFI) or a Request for Proposal (RFP), is commonly referred to as an RFx. It is part of the standard sales process within Public Sector, but can also happen with enterprise customers. The Field Security Team has created a process to assist and simplify the RFP process for GitLab field teams which you can view on the RFP Process Handbook page. Use the guidance below if you need help responding to an RFx outside of this process.

Best Practices for Writing RFx Responses

RFx is a general category that includes Request for Information, Request for Proposal, Request for Quote (RFQ), etc. RFIs are generally less structured than RFPs. While RFQs rarely need technical write ups, occasionally technical input is required, especially if the RFx requests an or alike product. Solutions Architects can have a big role in responding to RFIs and RFPs where there are a considerable number of technical asks and solutions requirements.

Evaluating RFIs and RFPs for Response

There is a saying used commonly when responding: Make sure you answer the mail. This has two connotations:

1. Evaluate what is asked for and make a best attempt to address it, and
1. Answer the questions directly and provide context

But more importantly, be sure that there is a product fit. If what is asked for in the RFI/RFP is not directly met with GitLab, or seems too much like a different software entirely, then stop and talk to the Strategic Account Executive or Inside Sales Representative. Also identify the strategic impact if the requirements do not seem to match GitLab functionality. If GitLab fits only a piece of the RFx, collaborate with the Strategic Account Executive and/or Inside Sales Representative to understand who the other players in the response might be.

Process of Responding to RFx

Generally, RFx's have a fixed timeline and require input from different functions within GitLab e.g. Solution Architects, Professional Services, Legal, etc.. The DRI (Direct Responsible Individual) is the Strategic Account Executive (SAE) for the Account. A GitLab issue assists in the coordination, task assignment and tracking of the progress. The best place to create the issue is in the Account project, if one exists, or in a central project where such activities are created and tracked. Occasionally, they can be created in an arbitrary personal project space and shared with other team members if no other suitable place can be found. Build an outline in the issue. The outline should include the following things:

1. Any customer's instructions regarding organization
1. A rational organization of information that will answer all of the questions and requirements
1. Easy to follow structure for the proposal document
1. Compliance with all requirements
1. Links to appropriate Account or Opportunity in Salesforce

Typically a SAE will create the issue and should be assigned to the issue along with the SA and other required team member. Lay out the tasks and assign owners so that every team member's duties are clear. And finally assign the due date according to the agreed-to completion date - at least 24-36 hours in advance of the published due date for the submission to the customer. This provides a small buffer in case of last minute adjustments or approvals that may be needed. In case ambiguity in the task assignment exists, a synchronous meeting with all relevant team members is recommended to speed up the process.

Responding to RFx

After the issue is created, create a Google document and start filling in the details. Insert the Google document link to the working document into the issue.

In the event that the RFx requires:

- A security questionnaire or legal review, please follow the process described on the RFP Process page in the handbook.
- A professional services component, the Selling Professional Services handbook page will be of help.

Each of these processes will likely require the creation of issues. Be sure to link these issues to the main response issue for tracking purposes.

Recommendation: The response documents should be placed in the appropriate Sales Account directory/folder in Google Drive. Please include the link to that document in the Catalog Document for others to be able to find easily and reuse.

Specifics about RFIs

RFIs are generally issued to shape procurement. In some situations, RFIs are just a step in the process as the customer may already have an advising team that may be following protocol. An RFI is generally non-binding unless otherwise specified. Responses to questions in an RFI don't have to be precise. They can have some idealistic statements to lay the groundwork and pivot points to educate the customer on what GitLab offers. It is good to follow the GitLab Value

Framework response methodology, as there is no ability to have a dialog. The RFI is about positioning. Provide context around the following factors that can grab the attention of the readers:

- Positioning and value of the product
- Truth about capabilities
- Solution options and flexibility
- How risk is mitigated by the solution

Some RFIs have a length limit, but be sure to verify and be mindful if there is one. Start with a simple overview of what the product does. GitLab Marketing does a great job with text that is vetted. For example, utilize the write-ups for each of the Stages of the DevOps Workflow. Do not reinvent the wheel, especially for an RFI. Keep it simple and succinct.

An RFI may ask open-ended questions. This is good for providing detailed solution responses. Keep the language simple and describe the solution GitLab offers. Instead of stating that GitLab does or does not do something, direct the reader to why GitLab doesn't do it, if it is on the roadmap, or how they would implement a workaround.

When responding to an RFI, it's critical to document how the product solves customer problems, but it's also important to include the company behind the product. GitLab's all-remote leadership, its company values, its culture, and its professional services offerings shape the entire customer relationship.

Including Links to Documentation

In general, for Public Sector responses, adding links to documentation is not a good practice. Essentially, anything that makes a reader have to do extra work is not going to work well. There are also cases in which the reader may not be able to readily access the link provided.

For example, if the question asks for a Roadmap for the next product release, it is a good idea to include a link to our roadmap, but then also explain GitLab's release velocity and consistency so the customer understands the dynamic nature of the GitLab release process. Another instance when links are desirable is when relevant customer use cases may be referenced.

If, however, the customer asks for a descriptive concept like the architecture of GitLab, use that as a way to include as much detail as possible inline, a summary of why the architecture is what it is, including the benefits, and then a link for them to read more. Also, including images and screenshots is highly encouraged where possible.

The customer may ask for a description of the CI process or other complex process. In these cases, it is acceptable to copy as much of the documentation from our documentation as possible, including many details to differentiate GitLab from competitive products. Using CI as an example, include a description of how GitLab CI operates, a description of the yml file, a link to the yml file documentation, and add information regarding unique or differentiating functions that GitLab offers like Auto DevOps, Directed Acyclic Graphs, multi-project pipelines, etc.

Tips and Tricks in Response Writing

- As much as possible use active rather than passive voice
- Eliminate pronouns: Example 1, "GitLab CI will do x" rather than "Our CI will do x". Example 2, "The GitLab team will x" rather than "We will x".
- Organization of the response is as important as the content
- Create a strong introduction and summary leveraging existing Marketing information which presents the breadth of the entire GitLab solution
- If specific requirements are expected to be answered by the response, add notations to the requirement number being met within the text of the response: Example, "GitLab's SAST scanner will analyze your source code for known vulnerabilities (Req 1.a.1)"
- Use customer terminology wherever possible
- Include relevant customer use cases whenever possible

Links to Completed RFPs

For Gitlab Team members, please see list here.

SECTION: solutions-architects/tools-and-resources/trial-guidelines.md

By default, GitLab allows you to trial the entire AI powered DevSecOps platform for free. This gives you full access to nearly all the Ultimate-tier and GitLab Duo features.

With GitLab, teams can collaborate through the entire Software Development Lifecycle from a single tool, allowing you to develop and deploy more secure software, faster.

Trialing GitLab will allow you to understand if this solution is the right one for your specific needs and will help you to make an informed decision.

However, the trial period will pass by in the blink of an eye! As the experiment will happen in parallel to your regular activities, it is important to properly scope and prepare. Here are some tips and best practices to maximize the value of your trial.

Scoping the Trial

A trial is successful when you have been able to use the time allowed to complete your evaluation end-to-end while every decision maker was able to understand if the solution solves their problems, brings value and delivers a return on investment.

What are the objectives of the trial?

This is the most important step and will help to ensure an efficient trial. We recommend setting up 3 key goals to validate in 30 days. The goals can be specific problems you are trying to solve, use cases that you want to validate,...

Next, make a list of the features that you will need to configure to support these goals and sort the "must haves" versus "good to haves".

There are hundreds of features in GitLab, make sure you focus on implementing the ones that support your goals. You can refer to this list of features per stages of the software

development life cycle. The rest can be added to the backlog to test at a later stage once the main goals have been evaluated.

How will success be measured against these objectives?

Define your success metrics and specific KPIs for each goal. What does it mean to achieve the goals? How will you know if this goal has been accomplished?

Make sure you have a baseline to compare to. This is particularly important once you conclude the trial to establish a clear before / after comparison and will be helpful to share with all stakeholders in the decision process.

What does the decision process look like?

Understand how you will take the decision at the end of the evaluation:

- What information do you need?
- How will you present the results?
- Who will decide what the next steps are?
- What is the exact decision you need to make? Do you merely need to decide to purchase the solution? Or are there other joint decisions such as migrating from existing tools?

Who should participate?

Identify all the team members in the organization who should participate in the trial.

1. Start by designating a project coordinator.

1. List the people who will need to take part in the final decision making process. Who needs to be an active participant in the trial? Who only needs to view a final report with the findings to take the decision? This list could include:

- The budget owners
- The impacted team leads and key representatives
- C-level sponsor

1. Identify the people who will be responsible for implementing and setting up the test inside GitLab.

There is no ideal number as it depends on the size of your company and the scope of the evaluation. However, from our experience, it is best to limit the number to a small team (3 to 10 people max)

At the end of the day, it is important to find a balance:

- With a single person leading the trial, there is a risk of not sufficiently accounting for all users' needs. Other stakeholders involved in the evaluation may have limited access to the results of the trial.
- With a large team, it can be difficult to coordinate the collection of inputs and feedback, align agendas to organize regular check-ins on the trial process,...

Before getting started, understand the goals and success criteria for each participant. Make sure they all have the information to get started (the goals, the feature list to implement, the documentation,...).

Which projects should be used for testing?

For larger organizations, the trial will be too short to test across every single project. Therefore, it's good to limit the scope to a few projects where you will be able to implement all the functionalities to validate your use cases.

The selected projects need to be representative enough for the evaluation. Based on our experience, testing on 1 to 3 projects can provide significant results.

For example, an organization evaluating the security and compliance capabilities of GitLab would benefit from testing on 3 projects: a backend, a front end, and an Infrastructure as Code project.

How to plan the evaluation?

The evaluation should begin when the participants have the bandwidth to take on the trial alongside their regular activities.

Defining a schedule is helpful to make sure that the evaluation will complete on time. Here is an example:

- Week 0:
 - Kick off meeting
- Week 1 to week 3:
 - 15 to 30 min weekly stand up meeting to keep track of the progress, what is still to be evaluated and to alleviate any blockers or highlight shifts in priorities
- Week 4:
 - Conclude the evaluation and review the metrics achieved for each goal to measure the success of the trial
 - Prepare the internal presentation to the final decision makers if they are not part of the trial team
 - Documenting the whole process with the goals, metrics and weekly progresses will improve collaboration among participants and facilitate the decision process at the end.

Activating the Ultimate trial

The Ultimate trial is active for a duration of 30 days and can be requested for new GitLab users or existing GitLab customers on a Premium tier, both on GitLab.com and GitLab Self Managed.

I am new to GitLab

- Head to the Trial Landing page on the GitLab's marketing website
- Choose between SaaS or Self Managed
- Follow the instructions to set up your account
- Choosing Self Managed will require some additional configuration as you will first need to install the instance
- Once the trial is activated, you will gain access to a free Ultimate tier trial

I already have a company account

There are two options:

Create a dedicated trial account

Follow the previous instructions "I am new to GitLab" and create a new group for example "organization-trial".

To populate the group with project data you can use the following methods:

Use copies of your own existing groups/projects

- Copy Groups and Projects
 - When copying from one GitLab.com namespace to another, you must copy all subgroups and projects. This is not recommended for customers with a large number of groups and projects.
 - Only these groups items are migrated, no others
 - Only these project items are migrated. Note these are the same project items that are migrated with file exports (described in the next section)
- Migrate Projects using file exports
 - Only these project items are migrated.
- Project Forking
 - This works like standard forking with a copy of the repository and branches
 - You will not have access to a lot of the project items that you get with the previous two approaches
- Repository Mirroring
 - Any of the above approaches can be combined with mirroring to make sure that branches, tags, and commits are synced
 - Items such as Merge Requests and issues are not synced

Use GitLab Security demo projects

GitLab provides a set of security demos to show how the various security scans work.

Trial in your existing account

| Subscription type | Process |

| ----- | ----- |

| SaaS Free | In your account, go to Settings > Billing and request the trial |

| SaaS Premium | GitLab recently added the possibility to trial Ultimate inside your existing SaaS Premium namespace. For now, there is no self-serve option to activate it. Please contact your Account Executive or send a request |

| Self Managed Community Edition | You first need to follow these steps to upgrade your instance to the Enterprise Edition. Then follow the steps from the trial landing page to get a free trial license key |

| Self Managed Enterprise Edition Premium | We recommend first making sure you are on the latest version of GitLab Enterprise Edition for an optimal experience of the most recent features. If not, follow these steps to upgrade. Once on the latest version, contact your Account Executive or send a request to receive a trial license key. |

How do I choose?

| | Pros | Cons |

|--|-----|-----|

| Trial in a dedicated trial account | Focus on the use cases and functionalities to test in an isolated environment, limited to trial participants | Need to import and configure projects. On Self Managed, requires to configure a new instance and runners. |

| Trial in your existing account | Nothing to configure, test the features within your existing workflow. Value can be seen by all users. | Could create confusion as users not involved in the trial may come across new functionalities associated with an enterprise edition of GitLab if these users are unaware that a trial is taking place. |

Notes Regarding Trial Licenses

- If a Premium Trial is required instead of an Ultimate trial, then the customer should request the trial license as defined above. Then the GitLab Account Executive must create a GitLab Support Internal Request (Internal) in order to downgrade the Trial license from Ultimate to Premium. Use either the GitLab Support Internal Requests for Global customers or GitLab Support Internal Requests for Federal customers request option, then select the Self-Managed Trial related - Modify an existing Self-managed trial request type. GitLab Support will create a Premium license and email it to the user.

SaaS trials have the following limitations:

- If you are activating the trial as a new or Free GitLab user, there will be no access to customer support during the trial.
- GitLab shared runners available (with credit card verification) but the number of minutes is limited. If additional minutes are required, the GitLab Sales team can request an increase on the customer's behalf. Trialing in a dedicated SaaS group will be limited to 400 CI compute minutes per month.
- Only one Project Access Tokens is available with a trial license and Group Access Tokens are not available on a trial license.

If you are an existing Premium customer on GitLab SaaS and trialing Ultimate in your current namespace, the above limitations do not apply.

Extending an Existing Trial

All internal requests regarding licensing, subscriptions, trials, and grace period extensions should be filed using the GitLab Support Internal Request form. Customers should not be cc'd on Internal Requests.

Once accessed the form, enter the email and choose "GitLab L&R Internal Request for Global Customers" or "GitLab L&R Internal Request for US Federal Customers" to renew and extend a trial license.

Note you also need to have Zendesk Light Agent account before you make this request.

References

- Support Internal Requests
- Support Super Form

Trialing GitLab Duo (AI)

The GitLab Duo add on can only be purchased by paid Premium and Ultimate customers. The Duo trial is available for up to 60 days.

New users can trial in GitLab.com after first requesting an Ultimate trial.

It is not possible to trial Duo in Self Managed instances with Community Edition or Enterprise Edition without a license (Free).

An Ultimate Subscription is required to trial GitLab Duo Enterprise. A Premium Subscription is required to trial GitLab Duo P